🎷 The 1920s & Harlem Renaissance: Reading

US History · Unit 9 · Level 3 (closer to the class work) · goes with Great Migration notes, Jacob Lawrence, Langston Hughes, jazz, Prohibition and gangsters, The Century: Boom to Bust

Name: _____

The Roaring Twenties

Between 1910 and 1970 about 6 million Black Americans left the rural South for cities in the North and West in the Great Migration. They were pushed out by Jim Crow laws, racist violence, sharecropping debt and the boll weevil, which wrecked cotton crops. They were pulled north by factory jobs that opened during World War I and by newspapers like the Chicago Defender. Painter Jacob Lawrence later told this story in his 60-panel Migration Series.

Life in the North was freer but not equal. In the “Red Summer” of 1919, white mobs attacked Black communities in Chicago and dozens of other cities. In 1921 a white mob destroyed Greenwood, a prosperous Black neighborhood in Tulsa, Oklahoma, known as “Black Wall Street.” As many as 300 people were killed and thousands left homeless. For decades the massacre was left out of history books.

In Harlem, New York, Black writers, artists and musicians created the Harlem Renaissance. Langston Hughes's poem “I, Too” declared, “I, too, sing America.” Zora Neale Hurston wrote novels and collected Black folk stories. Jazz, a music with Black roots built on rhythm and improvisation, spread from New Orleans to Chicago and New York through Louis Armstrong, Duke Ellington and Bessie Smith. Yet clubs like the Cotton Club featured Black performers while admitting only white customers, and racist minstrel shows were still popular.

In 1920 the 18th Amendment and the Volstead Act began Prohibition, banning the making and sale of alcohol. Instead of ending drinking, Prohibition created speakeasies, bootleggers and powerful gangsters such as Chicago's Al Capone, who was finally convicted of tax evasion in 1931. Fast cars built to outrun police helped start stock car racing. The 21st Amendment repealed Prohibition in 1933.

New consumer goods such as Ford's affordable Model T, radios and movies changed daily life. Flappers, young women with bobbed hair and short skirts, challenged old rules about how women should act. Not everyone welcomed these changes. In the 1925 Scopes Trial, a Tennessee teacher was prosecuted for teaching evolution, showing the conflict between traditional beliefs and modern ideas.

Check your reading

1. Give two push and two pull factors for the Great Migration.

2. What happened in Tulsa in 1921?

3. What were the unintended effects of Prohibition?